may have compromised on the chances of making a success of his innovation.

It was now Ratan against a world of sceptics and nervous automobile manufacturers who feared a reduction in the demand for their vehicles. ‘I think my friend Carlos Ghosn [former CEO of Renault-Nissan, among others] has been the only person in the automotive area who has not scoffed at this [the Nano] … From day one he just said that it is possible in a place like India, but not possible anywhere else,’ said Ratan in an interview in 2008. But in India, too, there was opposition to the project.

V. Sumantran, executive director of Tata Motors’ passenger car business, says that during a meeting of the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM), a car manufacturer and a two-wheeler company viscerally opposed the Nano. They feared that it would negatively impact their businesses.

Ratan was, however, undaunted. He handpicked the best from Tata Motors for the project. Girish Wagh was made the principal architect of the 500-strong team. There were many challenges that had to be addressed. The idea of such an affordable car demanded some high levels of innovation. New vendors had to be found and familiarized with the new design and parts at challenging prices.

No idea was off the table to build a true people’s car. The team even wondered whether to make a four-wheel vehicle from scooter parts. Ratan also addressed an Automotive Component Manufacturers’ Association (ACMA) meeting and suggested that they join hands to ‘produce an Asian peoples’ car’, a ‘low cost car that Malaysia, Indonesia and India could come together to produce jointly’. The idea, however, did not catch the manufacturers’ fancy.

The core team then planned to build a three-wheel model, but soon abandoned the thought in case it might look tacky and be uncomfortable for the customer. It then veered around the idea of a low-end ‘rural car’ without doors; instead, it would have safety bars, similar to the six-seater public-transport vehicles popular in smaller towns and villages. Adding soft shutters and even plastic curtains that could be rolled down was toyed with. These ideas did not finally find favour with the team as it was feared that the market would not respond well to it.

Since the car had to be aesthetically appealing, Ratan accorded high priority to its design. With this aim, he initially outsourced the design work